but it turns out that there still survive some of his intelligence reports, including his writings about Burnes and his unravelling of the entire British spy network in Bukhara. These reports appear here in English for the first time.

The real breakthrough, however, was finding the astonishingly rich seam of Afghan sources for the period that turned up in Kabul. In 2009, while staying at Rory Stewart's mud fort near the ruins of the burned-out Curzon-era British Embassy, I began working in the Afghan National Archives. The archives, which are located in a surprisingly undamaged and rather beautiful Ottoman-style nineteenth-century palace in the centre of Kabul, turned out to have disappointingly little material from the era of Shah Shuja and Dost Mohammad. But it was while digging in the stacks there that I befriended Jawan Shir Rasikh, a young Afghan historian and Fulbright scholar. One lunchtime, Jawan Shir took me to a second-hand book dealer who occupied an unpromising-looking stall at Jowy Sheer in the old city. The dealer, it turned out, had bought up many of the private libraries of Afghan noble families as they emigrated during the 1970s and 1980s, and in less than an hour I managed to acquire eight previously unused contemporary Persian-language sources for the First Afghan War, all of them written in Afghanistan during or in the aftermath of the British defeat, but in several cases printed on Persian presses in India for domestic Indian consumption in the run-up to the great uprising of 1857.

The sources consist of two remarkable heroic epic poems – the *Akbarnama*, or The History of Wazir Akbar Khan, of Maulana Hamid Kashmiri, and the *Jangnama*, or History of the War, by Mohammad Ghulam Kohistani Ghulami, both of which read like Afghan versions of *The Song of Roland*, and were written in the 1840s in sonorous Persian modelled on that of the ancient Shahnameh of Ferdowsi to praise the leaders of the Afghan resistance. These epics seem to be the last survivors of what was probably once a very rich seam of poetry dedicated to the Afghan victory, much of it passed orally from singer to singer, bard to bard: after all, to the Afghans their victory over the British was an almost miraculous deliverance, their Trafalgar, Waterloo and Battle of Britain rolled into one.[7]

The single known copy of the *Jangnama* turned up in Parwan in 1951 lacking its front and end pages, and written on East India Company paper apparently looted from the British headquarters in Charikar. It focuses on the deeds of the Kohistani resistance leader Mir Masjidi, the Naqsbandi Sufi